

OCR LATIN A LEVEL

SCANSION

GUIDE TO LATIN METRE



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Introduction

This booklet begins with simple concepts but quickly becomes more challenging, so take a moment to pause after each half-page to check that you have understood the content before moving on.

Poetry that is 'pleasant-sounding' can be described as **euphonic**. What is 'pleasant-sounding' is, of course, subjective but the speech patterns of English mean that our ears are naturally drawn to poetry that is characterised by **accentual rhythms and rhyme schemes**. This means that each line has a fixed number of **stressed syllables**, and often the final syllables of each line will be similar-sounding to provide us with **a sense of melody and closure**.

Read aloud this first verse of the English nursery rhyme *Baa Baa Black Sheep*, exaggerating the stressed syllables which have been highlighted for you in bold:

Baa, baa, black sheep,	(4)
Have you any wool?	(5)
Yes sir, yes sir,	(4)
Three bags full;	(3)
One for the master,	(5)
And one for the dame	(5)
And one for the little boy	(7)
Who lives down the lane.	(5)

Notice how each line has two stressed syllables regardless of its total number (displayed in the brackets), and how the syllables/words that rhyme ('wool and full' and 'dame and lane') are stressed, emphasising the melody and closure.

This rhythmic framework of poetry is called **metre**. English metre, therefore, is determined by the arrangement of **stressed and unstressed syllables**.

Poets choose specific metres depending on the genre of their work, and their style. One of the beauties of poetry across all languages stems from a poet's ability to break the rules and deviate from their established metre to surprise their audience with fresh rhythms.

For example, William Blake's poem *The Tyger* is written in trochaic tetrameter with catalexis (four pairs of stressed and unstressed syllables, with the final unstressed syllable removed) except for its final line which is written in iambic tetrameter (four pairs of unstressed and stressed syllables). Read aloud its first verse exaggerating the syllables as before, then do so again while trying to stress the unstressed syllables and *vice versa*:

Tyger! Tyger! Burning bright,	(7)
In the forests of the night,	(7)
What immortal hand or eye	(7)
Could frame thy fearful symmetry?	(8)

Notice how the original metre complements the exclamatory opening and emphasises the rhyme of 'bright' and 'night', creating a chiaroscuro effect which highlights the tiger's fearsome beauty. Notice also how the final line's iambic metre creates a rising tone, indicating that it is a question, but when the metre is inverted all these effects are lost and the verse's clarity of meaning diminishes.

Latin poetry is fundamentally different to English poetry. The arrangement of stressed and unstressed syllables does not affect Latin metre. The final syllables of Latin words, because of the noun ending system, are so commonly identical that rhyming was avoided in verse and considered **unsophisticated**.

Instead, Latin poetry is characterised by **quantitative rhythms**. This means that the focus is not on the stress of the syllables but instead on **the time it takes to pronounce the syllables** which is called **quantity**. Syllables can be described as **either long or short**. Generally speaking, a long syllable takes **twice as long to pronounce as a short syllable**. This is their notation:

A long syllable is marked by a macron: —

A short syllable is marked by a breve: ˘

An uncertain syllable is marked by an anceps: ×

Latin metre, therefore, is determined by the arrangement of **long and short syllables**, and it is their arrangement that will also provide us with **a sense of melody and closure**.

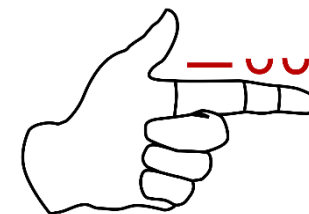
The way we identify the beginning and end of a syllable in Latin is by **looking at vowels**, which is similar to English. The rules below might sound convoluted but, in practice, they will feel intuitive:

VCV: if a consonant (C) is between two vowels (V), pronounce it with the second syllable, e.g. *Ovidius* → *O-vi-di-us*.

VCCV: if multiple consonants are between two vowels, pronounce the first with the preceding syllable and the rest with the second syllable, e.g. *Vergilius* → *Ver-gil-i-us*.

A combination of two or more syllables is called **a foot** (after the Greek *pous*) because they move through the verse at a measured pace. There are only **two** types of feet you need to be aware of.

The first is called a **dactyl** (from the Greek *daktylos* meaning 'finger') and consists of **one long and two short syllables** (— ˘˘) because each finger consists of one long and two short joints.



The second is called a **spondee** (from the Greek *sponde* meaning 'libation') and consists of **two long syllables** (— —) because it was originally used in the slow chant which accompanied libation ceremonies. We'll revisit these etymologies later on.

Notice how both the dactyl and spondee are of equal quantity, and how both begin with a long syllable so **every line must also begin with a long syllable**.

For some, it is useful to think of Latin verse as music. Long syllables take twice as long to pronounce as short syllables, just like crotchets and minims, and the long syllable at the beginning of every foot serves as a downbeat. For others, it is useful to think of long and short syllables as 'dum' and 'diddy' or 'boom' and 'shaka'.

Try not to feel discouraged by these new terms and concepts – quantitative verse feels alien to every English speaker initially. Remember the difference between reading Blake's poetry as it was intended to be read versus when it was metrically inverted, and look forward to how Latin will sound when read properly.

Dactylic Hexameter

A line of poetry which consists of six feet is called **hexameter**. Originally dactylic hexameter meant that all six feet were dactyls, but classical metre allows for **dactyls to be replaced by spondees in the first four feet**. The last five syllables are always the same:

— $\overline{UU}$ / — $\overline{UU}$ / — // $\overline{UU}$ / — $\overline{UU}$ / — UU / — X

According to mythology, dactylic hexameter was invented by the first Pythia of Delphi who would chant his oracles in this metre. The Greeks then chose dactylic hexameter as the medium for **epic**, and the Romans then modified it slightly to work in Latin. It is also the metre used for **didactic, pastoral, and satirical poetry**.

Dactylic Pentameter

A line of poetry which consists of five feet is called **pentameter**. However, the name is slightly misleading because its five feet are split into **two sets of two-and-a-half feet**. Classical metre allows for **dactyls to be replaced by spondees in the first two feet**. The last eight syllables are always the same:

— $\overline{UU}$ / — $\overline{UU}$ / — ||| — UU / — UU / X

Dactylic pentameter is rarely used on its own. A line of dactylic hexameter followed by a line of dactylic pentameter is called **an elegiac couplet**. The Romans used this combination of metres as the medium for **love poetry**, and other themes which were considered less grand than epic.

These are the only two metres you need to know. Memorise them.

Elision

When a word ends in a vowel and the next word begins with a vowel, the two slur together – this is called **elision**. Elision is a linguistic phenomenon present in every language. In English, it commonly occurs after 'the' and 'to', e.g. the army → th'army. **Elision is marked by a curved line connecting the words below:** 

The Romans **tried to avoid elision**, and you have already seen this occur in prose with prepositions like *a* and *e* becoming *ab* and *ex* if the noun they govern begins with a vowel. Elision is sometimes unavoidable but often poets will use it to create special effects.

The length of the second vowel determines the length after elision. When scanning and reading aloud, it can be useful to imagine replacing the ending of the first word with an apostrophe, as showcased by this phrase from Virgil's proem to the *Aeneid*:

multum ille et terris iactatus et alto → *mult'ill'et terris iactatus et alto*.

With elision, there are two exceptions to keep in mind. Firstly, the letter H is neither a consonant nor a vowel in Latin but can be described as **an aspirate**, meaning it simply tells you to exhale. Hence, if a word ends in a vowel and the next begins with the letter H, the two words elide. Secondly, if a word ends in the letter M and the next begins with a vowel (or H), the two words also elide.

For the letter H, remove the ending of the first word and the H itself, e.g. *omnia haec* → *omni'aec*. For the letter M, remove the M and its preceding vowel, e.g. *medium ad* → *medi'ad*. For instances of elision involving *es* and *est*, remove their *e* rather than removing the ending of the first word, e.g. *bonum est* → *bonum'st*.

Caesura and Diaeresis

Every line of Latin poetry contains a break **near the middle** to prevent the rhythm from becoming monotonous and to allow the speaker to breathe. Remember that much of Greek and Latin poetry was developed and shared orally, as Charles Jalabert illustrated in his painting *Horace, Virgil and Varius at the house of Maecenas* (the image on the front cover of this booklet).

A minor break between words that is within a foot is called **caesura**. In dactylic hexameter, a caesura will most often be **within the third foot, after its opening long syllable**. If there is no caesura within the third foot, it should be compensated for by two caesuras **within the second and fourth feet, after their respective opening syllables**.

Caesura does not need to imply a pause in the sense of the line but should not injure the sense of the line either. This means, for instance, that if you think your caesura is between a preposition and the noun it governs, you have probably made a mistake.

The end of a foot does not count as a break in the metre of a line. This is one of the hardest concepts to grasp for English speakers, and it does not help that the notation is so similar:

A foot is marked by **a forward slash: /**

A caesura is marked by **two forward slashes: //**

You will realise that the position of a caesura in a line of Latin poetry often corresponds to where scholars insert commas, for example after Virgil's famous *incipit: arma virumque cano*, (—UU/—UU/—||). For those who find it useful to think of Latin verse as music, feet are like bar lines and caesuras are like breath marks.

In Latin poetry, it is undesirable for **the end of a word to coincide with the end of a foot**. When this does occur, it can signal a dramatic break called **diaeresis**. However, just like with caesura, a diaeresis does not need to imply a pause in the sense of the line.

The symbol for a diaeresis is **three vertical lines: |||**. In dactylic hexameter, diaeresis is far less common than caesura but can be desirable between **the fourth and fifth feet**, and commonly occurs between **the fifth and sixth feet**. In dactylic pentameter, a diaeresis is what **separates the two sets of two and a half feet**.

Below is an annotated version of Virgil's proem to the *Aeneid*:

arma virumque cano, // Trojae qui primus ab oris
Italiam, // fato profugus // Lauiniaque venit
litora, // multum ille et terris iactatus et alto
ui superum // saevae memorem // Iunonis ob iram.

syllable
foot
elision
caesura
diaeresis

Notice how the caesura on line 1 suggests a comma, how caesura occurs in every third foot, and how diaeresis – with the exception of line 3 – typically occurs between the fourth, fifth and sixth feet.

Identifying the caesura is helpful in breaking up the line into more manageable chunks, but is also essential to understanding the euphony of Latin poetry. Its presence gives animation to a line, and without it, verse has little to distinguish it from common prose.

Noun endings

		Declension							
		First	Second (m, n)		Third (m/f, n)		Fourth (m/f, n)		Fifth
Singular	NOM	-ā	-ūs / -er	-um	- / -īs	- / -īs	-ūs	-ū	-ēs
	VOC	-ā	-ē	-um	- / -īs	- / -īs	-ūs	-ū	-ēs
	ACC	-am	-um	-um	-em	- / -īs	-um	-ū	-em
	GEN	-ae	-ī	-ī	-īs	-īs	-ūs	-ūs	-eī
	DAT	-ae	-ō	-ō	-ī	-ī	-ūī	-ū	-eī
	ABL	-ā	-ō	-ō	-ē / -ī	-ē / -ī	-ū	-ū	-ē
Plural	NOM	-ae	-ī	-ā	-ēs	-(ī)ā	-ūs	-ūā	-ēs
	VOC	-ae	-ī	-ā	-ēs	-(ī)ā	-ūs	-ūā	-ēs
	ACC	-ās	-ōs	-ā	-ēs / īs	-(ī)ā	-ūs	-ūā	-ēs
	GEN	-ārum	-ōrum	-ōrum	-(ī)um	-um	-ūum	-ūum	-ērum
	DAT	-īs	-īs	-īs	-ībūs	-ībūs	-ībūs	-ībūs	-ēbūs
	ABL	-īs	-īs	-īs	-ībūs	-ībūs	-ībūs	-ībūs	-ēbūs

cf. p32
RE. -eī.

N.B. the quantity of noun endings which end with the letter M have not been marked since they will either elide (and be determined by the length of the second vowel) or become long by position.

Pronouns and Verbs

First Person (sg.)	
NOM	<i>ĕgŏ</i>
ACC	<i>mē</i>
GEN	<i>meī</i>
DAT	<i>mīhī / mīhĭ / mī</i>
ABL	<i>mē</i>

Second Person (sg.)	
NOM	<i>tū</i>
ACC	<i>tē</i>
GEN	<i>tuī</i>
DAT	<i>tĭbī / tĭbĭ</i>
ABL	<i>tē</i>

First Person (pl.)	
NOM	<i>nōs</i>
ACC	<i>nōs</i>
GEN	<i>nostrum / nostrī</i>
DAT	<i>nōbīs</i>
ABL	<i>nōbīs</i>

Second Person (pl.)	
NOM	<i>vōs</i>
ACC	<i>vōs</i>
GEN	<i>vestrum, vestrī</i>
DAT	<i>vōbīs</i>
ABL	<i>vōbīs</i>

		Gender		
		Masculine	Feminine	Neuter
Singular	NOM	<i>īs</i>	<i>ea</i>	<i>īd</i>
	ACC	<i>eum</i>	<i>eam</i>	<i>id</i>
	GEN	<i>eius</i>	<i>eius</i>	<i>eius</i>
	DAT	<i>eī</i>	<i>eī</i>	<i>eī</i>
	ABL	<i>eō</i>	<i>eā</i>	<i>eō</i>
Plural	NOM	<i>eī</i>	<i>eae</i>	<i>ea</i>
	ACC	<i>eōs</i>	<i>eās</i>	<i>ea</i>
	GEN	<i>eōrum</i>	<i>eārum</i>	<i>eōrum</i>
	DAT	<i>eīs</i>	<i>eīs</i>	<i>eīs</i>
	ABL	<i>eīs</i>	<i>eīs</i>	<i>eīs</i>

		Gender		
		Masculine	Feminine	Neuter
Singular	NOM	<i>quī</i>	<i>quae</i>	<i>quod</i>
	ACC	<i>quem</i>	<i>quam</i>	<i>quod</i>
	GEN	<i>cuius</i>	<i>cuius</i>	<i>cuius</i>
	DAT	<i>cuī</i>	<i>cuī</i>	<i>cuī</i>
	ABL	<i>quō</i>	<i>quā</i>	<i>quō</i>
Plural	NOM	<i>quī</i>	<i>quae</i>	<i>quae</i>
	ACC	<i>quōs</i>	<i>quās</i>	<i>quae</i>
	GEN	<i>quōrum</i>	<i>quārum</i>	<i>eōrum</i>
	DAT	<i>quibus</i>	<i>quibus</i>	<i>quibus</i>
	ABL	<i>quibus</i>	<i>quibus</i>	<i>quibus</i>

Prosody

The guiding principles for determining quantity are called **prosody**. There are two over-arching principles which indicate that a syllable is long: **'long by nature'** and **'long by position'**.

A syllable is said to be long by nature if it contains a long vowel. However, there are no general principles to determining whether a vowel is long or not – they have to be learned from a dictionary which states vowel quantity, i.e. *Lewis & Short* or wiktionary.org. For example, the word *futurus* contains three of the same vowels, but its proper pronunciation, *fūtūrūs* (ū — ū), is not guessable. This is unhelpful for us in an exam. But do not panic! You do not need to memorise all your vocabulary. On the previous page, you can see that the tables you have memorised all have specific quantities. **These are worth memorising with their quantities.**

A pair of adjacent vowels that are pronounced as one sound is called a **diphthong**. **A syllable is also said to be long by nature if it contains a diphthong.** Latin has six types of diphthongs:

- ae** → pronounced as *ai* in 'aisle', e.g. *puellae*.
- au** → pronounced as *ou* in 'house', e.g. *audio*.
- ei** → pronounced as *ei* in 'reign', e.g. *deinde*.
- eu** → *e+u* said rapidly, e.g. *heu*.
- oe** → pronounced as *oi* in 'oil', e.g. *poena*.
- ui** → pronounced as 'wi', e.g. *hui*, *huic*, *huius*, *cui*, *cuius*.

N.B. the diphthong *ui* occurs only in the five examples stated, and elsewhere the letters are sounded separately, e.g. *fuit* → *fu-it*.

In Latin, the letter *I* has two functions, sometimes acting as **the vowel**, and other times acting as **a consonant (pronounced like the English Y)**; the letter *J* developed in the Middle Ages, so was unknown to the ancients. A vowel before the consonant *I* is often long because the words were originally written with the vowel *I* as well, creating a diphthong in the preceding syllable. For example, the genitive pronouns *cuius*, *huius* and *eius* were originally *cuiius*, *huiius* and *eiius* (pronounced *cui-yus* *hui-yus* and *ei-yus*) so their first syllables are all long.

Examine the table on page 5 and, by highlighting the noun endings which contain a long vowel or a diphthong, you should observe the following patterns:

- All singular genitive endings are long except for the third declension *-īs*.
- All singular dative endings have a long final syllable.
- All singular ablative endings are long except for the third declension ablative *ē* (though its alternative *ī* is long).
- All plural nominative, vocative and accusative endings for masculine and feminine nouns are long.
- All plural genitive endings in the first, second and fifth declensions have a long first syllable.
- All nouns which end in *i*, *o*, and *u* have a long final syllable.
- If a noun ends in *-ūs* it is second or fourth declension nominative singular (or fourth declension vocative singular).
- If a noun ends in *-īs* it is singular, if it ends in *īs* it is plural.
- If a noun ends in *-ā* it is first declension ablative singular.
- If a noun ends in *-ē* it is either second declension vocative or third declension ablative singular.

A syllable is said to be long by position if its vowel is followed by two or more consonants. Remember that there were originally no spaces in Latin text, so this rule can apply even across words. For example, *amor vincit omnia* has three syllables which become long by position: *a-mor-vin-cit-om-ni-a*. However, if a word ends in a short vowel and the next syllable contains two consonants, the vowel usually stays short, e.g. *puellā stat* (U — UU).

The letters QU and GU, when in combination, should be treated as single consonants (not as a consonant and a vowel).

The letters X and Z count as double consonants, meaning that whatever vowel precedes them is long by position but this does not apply across words. The letters L and R do not always count as second consonants if they come after a mute consonant (B, C, D, G, P, and T) in the same syllable. For example, the first syllable of *patris* is short despite *t* and *l* being adjacent, whereas the second syllable of *fi-at lux* is long because *t* and *l* are adjacent – and *lux* is long because *x* is a double consonant. These doubtful instances are not guessable but you should be aware of them.

These rules on how to identify long syllables are all you need to know because if a syllable is not long, it is short. The only rule on how to identify short syllables that is worth knowing is: if a pair of adjacent vowels are not pronounced as one sound (i.e. they are not a diphthong), the first vowel is short, e.g. the *u* of *puella*. For this reason, and because H is only an aspirate, the first vowel in words like *nihil* and *mihi* are short because they are considered adjacent to the next vowel (and are not pronounced as one sound).

Ametricity

If a word is impossible to include in dactylic metres because of its syllable combination, i.e. (— U —) or (U U U), it is called ametrical.

Some words are innately ametrical, for instance it might surprise you to learn that in the *Aeneid* – a poem about warlike soldiers and generals – Virgil never uses *bellicōsus -a -um* (— U — X), *impērātor* (— U — X) or *mīlitēs* (— U —).

This can sometimes explain why words which are popular in prose, are less popular in verse, e.g. *mārīā* (U U U) is ametrical and so *aequora* is used in verse (— U U), likewise *uēhērē* (U U U) is ametrical and so *uectāre* is used in verse (— — U).

Poets will often use singular and plural forms interchangeably – this is called poetic plural. This can sometimes be explained if the word is ametrical in its singular form, e.g. *gaudīum* when followed by a consonant becomes ametrical (— U —) but *gaudīa* does not.

Poets will often use a Greek term instead of a Latin term – this is called a Graecism. Often this is because of the Roman literary tradition stemming from Greek, but is sometimes due to its Greek synonym being more suitable for poetry, e.g. the accusative singular of *āēr* is often the Greek *āērā* (instead of the Latin *āērēm*).

Poets will often if it is necessary for their work. For instance, *rēlīgō* (UUU—) is ametrical and so Lucretius, in his criticism of Roman religion, simply lengthens its first syllable, making *rellīgō* (—UU—).

Peculiar nouns

Abstract nouns in Latin typically have the suffix *-tās -tātis* which all have a long *ā*, e.g. *cīvitās*, *dignitās*, *dignitātis*, *libertās*, *potestās*, *tempestās*. These popular terms are often ametrical so in verse a synonym will be used instead, e.g. *cūpīdō* (U — —) is used instead of *cūpīdītās* (U U U —).

Some third declension nouns, when in the ablative singular, end in *-ī* (instead of *ē*) meaning the quantity of their final is actually long, e.g. *febris*, *navis*, *puppis*, *securis* and *turris*.

Adjectives

Adjectives have the same endings as nouns, so work the same. It is worth noting that Ovid is especially fond of adjectives which have the suffix *-osus*, which all have a long *ō*, e.g. *formōsus -a -um*. Virgil, by contrast never uses *formōsus* in the *Aeneid* and instead opts for *pulcher* (which appears 44 times). Adverbs formed from adjectives of the first and second declension all end with a long *ē*, e.g. *formōsē*, *pulchrē*. But some adverbs, i.e. *benē* and *malē* do not.

Enclitics

Enclitics (*-ne*, *-que*, and *-ve*) are all short, but because they all begin with consonants they will often make the word they are attached to long by position, e.g. *populus* (UUU) → *populusque* (UU—U). Exclamations (*o*, *hei*, *ah*, *io*, *vae*, *vah*) are all long monosyllables.

Prepositions and Prefixes

The monosyllabic prepositions which end in a consonant (*ab*, *ad*, *in*, *ob*, *per*, *sub*) are often short but can become long by position. The exceptions, *post* and *trans*, both contain double consonants and *trans*, although it frequently drops its last two letters to become the prefix *tra-*, is still long. The monosyllabic prepositions which end in a vowel (*a*, *de*, *e*, *pro*) are all long, and remain long when used as prefixes. However, the prefix *re-* is short.

Accusative	
<i>ad</i>	U
<i>ante</i>	— U
<i>apud</i>	U U
<i>circā</i>	— —
<i>circiter</i>	— U U
<i>circum</i>	— U
<i>ergā</i>	— —
<i>extrā</i>	— —
<i>īnfrā</i>	— —
<i>inter</i>	— U
<i>intrā</i>	— —
<i>ob</i>	U
<i>per</i>	—
<i>post</i>	—
<i>prope</i>	— U
<i>propter</i>	— U
<i>trāns</i>	—
<i>ultrā</i>	— —

Ablative	
<i>ā</i> or <i>ab</i>	— or U
<i>cum</i>	U
<i>dē</i>	—
<i>ē</i> or <i>ex</i>	— or —
<i>sine</i>	U U

Either	
<i>prō</i>	—
<i>sub</i>	U
<i>in</i>	U
<i>super</i>	U U
<i>suprā</i>	U —

Verbs

Verbs that form the perfect tense through reduplication always have the reduplicated syllable (and often the second syllable) scanned as short, e.g. *cādō* becomes *cēcīdī*, whereas *caedō* becomes *cēcīdī*. This rule does not apply when the second syllable is long by position, e.g. *mōrdēō* becomes *mōmōrdī*.

Verbs which become disyllabic in the perfect tense mostly have their first syllable scanned as long, even if in the present tense it is short, e.g. *fūgīō* becomes *fūgī*. There are seven exceptions to this: *bibi*, *dedi*, *fīdi*, *scidi*, *steti*, *stīti*, and *tuli*.

Verbs which have a PPP ending in *-utus* have a penultimate syllable that is long, e.g. *solūtus*, *adiūtus*, *constitūtus*, *locūtus*, *secūtus*. Likewise verbs which have a PPP ending in *-itum* have a penultimate syllable that is long but only if their perfect has the

ending *-ivi*, e.g. *arcessītus*, *condītum cupītus*, *desītus*, *petītus*, *punītus*.

Infinitives				
	First	Second	Third	Fourth
Active	-āre	-ēre	-ere	-īre
Passive	-ārī	-ērī	-ī	-īrī

Imperatives				
	First	Second	Third	Fourth
Singular	-ā	-ē	-e	-ī
Plural	-āte	-ēte	-īte	-īte

		Indicative		Subjunctive	
		Active	Passive	Active	Passive
Singular	1 st	-ō	-r	-m	-r
	2 nd	-s	-ris	-s	-ris
	3 rd	-t	-tur	-t	-tur
Plural	1 st	-mus	-mur	-mus	-mur
	2 nd	-tis	-minī	-tis	-minī
	3 rd	-nt	-ntur	-nt	-ntur

N.B. the thematic vowels for the subjunctive are: *-ē-*, *-ēā-*, *-ā-*, *-īā-*

		Imperfect	Perfect	Pluperfect	Future pf.
Singular	1 st	-bam	-ī	-eram	-erō
	2 nd	-bās	-istī	-erās	-eris
	3 rd	-bat	-it	-erat	-erit
Plural	1 st	-bāmus	-imus	-erāmus	-erimus
	2 nd	-bātis	-istis	-erātis	-eritis
	3 rd	-bant	-ērunt -ēre	-erant	-erunt

Repetition

While the endings of words can vary in quantity, elide or become long by position, **if words are repeated their stems scan the same.**

Viewing the main caesura as what divides a line in half, Ovid often balances his lines or creates dichotomies by repeating words on either side of the caesura, for example in this line he highlights the antithetical experiences of two lovers:

speremus pariter, // pariter metuamus amantes

In his elegiac couplets, Ovid sometimes repeats the first word of the hexameter line as the last word of the pentameter line, making a minor change to its case/number/gender/declension – this is called **epanadiplosis**. For example in this line he emphasises a husband's lingering presence:

*vir tuus est epulas nobis aditurus easdem —
ultima coena tuo sit, precor, illa viro!*

An anecdote by Seneca reports how Ovid's friends recorded the two lines they hated most from his anthology, and how these two lines were coincidentally Ovid's favourite:

1. semibovemque virum semivirumque bovem
2. gelidum Borean egelidumque Notum

The first line describes the Minotaur and showcases Ovid's affection for repetition, and the second showcases his ability in creating dichotomies through subtle word manipulation.

Homographs

If two words are spelt the same but are different in sound and meaning, they are called **homographs**. In English, we are dependent on context to understand homographs otherwise it is completely ambiguous, e.g. Groucho Marx's famous saying "time flies like an arrow, and fruit flies like a banana." If you are unfamiliar with this saying, you should probably read it again.

In Latin, however, **homographs often differ in quantity to prevent confusion**. Here are some notable examples:

<i>aes aeris</i> , n. > bronze <i>aere</i>	<i>āēre</i> air < <i>āēr āēris</i> , m.
<i>alō</i> , -ere > nourish <i>alitis</i>	<i>ālitis</i> bird < <i>āles alitis</i> , c.
<i>dux ducis</i> , m. > leader <i>ducis</i>	<i>dūcis</i> , lead < <i>dūcō -ere</i>
<i>edō</i> -are > put forth <i>ēdō</i>	<i>edō</i> eat < <i>edo -ere</i>
<i>educō</i> -are > educate <i>ēducō</i>	<i>ēdūcō</i> lead out < <i>educo -ere</i>
<i>sum esse</i> > be <i>es</i>	<i>ēs</i> , eat < <i>edō -ere</i>
<i>fero ferre</i> > we bear <i>ferimus</i>	<i>ferīmus</i> we strike < <i>feriō -īre</i>
<i>lātus</i> -a -um > broad <i>lātus</i>	<i>latus</i> side < <i>latus lateris</i> , n.
<i>levis</i> > light <i>levis</i>	<i>lēvis</i> smooth < <i>lēvis -e</i>
<i>liber libri</i> , m. > book <i>liber</i>	<i>līber</i> free < <i>liber -a -um</i>
<i>malum</i> -ī, n. > evil-doing <i>malum</i>	<i>mālum</i> apple < <i>mālum -ī</i> , n.
<i>malus</i> -a -um > bad <i>malō</i>	<i>mālō</i> I prefer < <i>mālō mālle</i>
<i>māne</i> > in the morning <i>māne</i>	<i>manē</i> stay < <i>maneō -ēre</i>
<i>noscō</i> -ere > I know <i>nōvī</i>	<i>novī</i> new < <i>novus -a -um</i>
<i>occīdō</i> -ere > killed <i>occīdī</i>	<i>occidī</i> died < <i>occidō -ere</i>
<i>ōs ōris</i> , n. > mouth, face <i>ōra</i>	<i>ōrā</i> edge, border < <i>ōra -ae</i> , f.
<i>populus</i> , -ī m. > people <i>populus</i>	<i>pōpulus</i> poplar tree < <i>pōpulus -ī</i> f.
<i>vīs</i> , <i>vīrīs</i> > strength = <i>vīrīs</i>	<i>virīs</i> men < <i>vir virī</i> , m.

Ciceronian style

While Cicero is no poet, you have learned that every syllable in Latin has quantity – this is also true in prose. At the ends of his sentences, Cicero often creates a metrical pattern of euphonic cadence, called **clausula**. This is his most common clausula:

/ — u — / — X .

Clausula might make the final words of a speech **more memorable and engaging**, e.g. in *Pro Caelio* 53, the phrase (*non*) *esse credendam* (—u—/—X) repeats the beginning of its sentence but with a new, distinct meaning: it ‘should not be believed’ that someone as smart as Caelius did not realise that someone else’s slaves ‘should not be entrusted’ to do his bidding.

Virgilian style

Virgil wrote his *Eclogues*, *Georgics* and *Aeneid* in dactylic hexameter. By his death in BC, his works were already standard texts in Roman school curricula, and he was considered one of Rome’s greatest poets.

Virgil’s weighty and lofty style stems from his preference for spondees over dactyls, using them 12% more. He will sometimes (7%) use four spondees in succession which Ovid almost never does (2%).



Ovidian style

Ovid was first and foremost an elegiac poet. He is arguably the greatest (and claimed as much) – by the end of his career, he wrote this braggart elegiac:

*tantum se nobis elegi debere fatentur,
quantum Vergilio nobile debet epos.*



The following are **all written in elegiac couplets**: *Amores*, *Heroides*, *Ars Amatoria*, *Fasti*, and *Tristia* are all written in elegiac couplets. His *Metamorphoses*, however, is written in **dactylic hexameter**.

Ovid’s bouncy style stems from his preference for dactyls over spondees, using them 10% more. In *Metamorphoses* Books 1-5, the eight most common patterns of Ovidian hexameter (which account for over 81% of his lines) **all begin with a dactyl**, and half of these contain **three dactyls** (not counting the fifth-foot dactyl).

Ovid avoided elisions as much as possible, when they do occur it is often with words like *-que*, *et*, and *est* which are so common that they would not have disrupted the rhythm or clarity. Generally, in every ten lines of Ovid, there will only be one elision, and he does not elide **in the second half of the pentameters**. Ovid often uses the caesura to divide his phrases, so it can be especially important to truly understand the sense of a line, e.g. in the elegiac above, the comparison between himself (*nobis*) and Virgil (*Vergilio*) is framed by *tantum... quantum* but truly emphasised by the caesuras which make the speaker slightly pause after each name.

Examination technique

In your 'Unseen translation' paper, you will be asked to scan only two lines, selected from the passage of Ovid you must translate. Although it is on the last page, attempt the scansion question before translating the passage since it might reveal the cases or meanings of some words. After translating the passage, you should check that your scansion corroborates your grammar.

The question is worth five marks, and each mark is awarded based on how many feet you scan correctly – you can make one mistake and still achieve full marks. After a lot of practice, you will be able to read poetry from left to right, scanning it in your head as you go. In an exam, however, the safest way to scan will always be to treat each line like a puzzle and follow this step-by-step approach:

1. Look for elisions, remembering that words which begin with H, or end in M can elide too.
2. Look for diphthongs, noun endings, or verb endings which must be long by nature.
3. Look for any adjacent or double consonants (X and Z) which must be long by position, omitting any doubtful cases.
4. Check for any vowels or words which are short by position.
5. Mark the first syllable of the line as long.
6. Mark the last syllables of the line which are always the same. In hexameter this is the last five syllables (— uu / — X), in pentameter this is the last eight syllables (— uu / — uu / X).
7. Identify the caesura (only necessary in hexameter).
8. For the final syllables, make educated guesses based on the theoretical combinations which could occur. Remember, you cannot have a single short (—u—) or three shorts (uuu).

Overview

The marking of a line of poetry's feet and quantities is called **scansion**. The rest of this booklet presents ten themed exercises of increasing difficulty with some prompts for discussion which should help you practice scansion and appreciate its effects.

The lack of context and glossed vocabulary makes these exercises very difficult – when you look up vocabulary, use a dictionary that does not state vowel quantity, i.e. [Whitaker's Words Online](#), to simulate exam conditions.

Exercise 1: Two lines of hexameter

Watch Nicholas Oulton scan this two lines of hexameter ([1](#) & [2](#)), and elegiac couplet ([1](#) & [2](#)). Follow his application of the step-by-step approach, and do not feel as though it is cheating to look at the step-by-step approach during the first three exercises since they are designed to be in view of it:

tempus erat quo prima quies mortalibus aegris

incipit et dono divum gratissima serpit.

ultima Tarquinius Romanae gentis habebat.

regna, vir iniustus, fortis ad arma tamen.

Exercise 2: Syllables

Split the following words into syllables, marking the quantities that are discernable from the rules discussed:

<i>stetistis</i>	<i>cecinerint</i>	<i>pepulisse</i>
<i>maius</i>	<i>proelium</i>	<i>abietibus</i>
<i>deinde</i>	<i>huic</i>	<i>zmegmatis</i>
<i>abhinc</i>	<i>perietibus</i>	<i>cecidit</i>
<i>foveret</i>	<i>pupugi</i>	<i>demere</i>
<i>fugimus</i>	<i>perdiderit</i>	<i>laetae</i>
<i>dedisti</i>	<i>veni</i>	<i>credidero</i>
<i>pepigeram</i>	<i>dein</i>	<i>ariete</i>
<i>videmus</i>	<i>pependero</i>	<i>venisti</i>
<i>lingua</i>	<i>sanguis</i>	<i>bibi</i>
<i>foedus</i>	<i>videmus</i>	<i>tulit</i>
<i>cucurrerit</i>	<i>possum</i>	<i>lingua</i>
<i>audire</i>	<i>moenia</i>	<i>pepulisse</i>
<i>scidimus</i>	<i>perdidi</i>	<i>foedus</i>
<i>adhuc</i>	<i>abiete</i>	<i>dicere</i>
<i>nihilum</i>	<i>audivi</i>	<i>audio</i>
<i>stetissetis</i>	<i>expectat</i>	<i>curandi</i>
<i>pepulisse</i>	<i>fidit</i>	<i>poena</i>

What is the maximum and minimum number of syllables possible in a line of dactylic hexameter?

What patterns can appear in pentameter but not hexameter?

Exercise 3: Proem to *Metamorphoses*

Translate and scan:

in nova fert animus mutatas dicere formas
corpora; di, coeptis (nam vos mutastis et illas)
adspirare meis primaque ab origine mundi
ad mea perpetuum deducite tempora carmen.

Exercise 4: *sapere aude!*

Dare to be wise! Translate and now try – without looking back – to scan this passage of Horace from which the motto of the West London Free School comes:

... *et ni*

posces ante diem librum cum lumine, si non

intendes animum studiis et rebus honestis,

invidia vel amore vigil torquebere. nam cur

quae laedunt oculum, festinas demere: siquid

est animum, differs curandi tempus in annum?

dimidium facti, qui coepit, habet: sapere aude;

incipi! vivendi qui recte prorogat horam,

rusticus expectat dum defluat amnis; at ille

labitur et labetur in omne volubilis aevum.

What might the elision at Horace's syntactical pause suggest?

What makes the imperatives *aude* and *incipi* metrically powerful?

Exercise 5: Metrical etymologies and puns

There are numerous examples in both Greek and Latin poetry of puns about the physical and metrical meanings of 'feet', 'dactyls' and 'spondees' mentioned briefly on page 2. For each extract, first scan and then translate them (it will be helpful to do it in this order henceforth), and then jot down some ideas in answer to the prompts which we shall discuss further in class.

How do these lines illustrate the women Ovid desires, and how is his taste in women similar to his poetic style?

tu, quia tam longa es, veteres heroidas aequas

et potes in toto multa iacere toro.

haec habilis brevitae sua est. corrumpor utraque;

conveniunt voto longa brevisque meo.

How does the subject matter of the hexameter lines differ to that of the pentameter lines, and what might this suggest about Ovid's perspective on Rome's humble origins?

Aspice quae nunc sunt Capitolia, quaeque fuerunt:

Alterius dices illa fuisse Iovis.

Curia, concilio quae nunc dignissima tanto,

De stipula Tatio regna tenente fuit.

Quae nunc sub Phoebus ducibusque Palatia fulgent,

Quid nisi araturis pascua bubus erant?

How does Ovid in his opening to the *Ars Amatoria* allude to the proem of the *Aeneid* but justify writing elegiac couplets about love instead of writing a grand epic?

arma gravi numero violentaque bella parabam

edere, materia conveniente modis.

par erat inferior versus: risisse Cupido

dicitur atque unum surripuisse pedem.

'quis tibi, saeve puer, dedit hoc in carmina iuris?

peridum vates, non tua turba sumus.

quid, si praeripiat flavae Venus arma Minervae,

ventilet accensas flava Minerva faces?

quis probet in silvis Cererem regnare iugosis,

lege pharetratae virginis arva coli?

crinibus insignem quis acuta cuspide Phoebum

instruat, Aoniam Marte movente lyram?

sunt tibi magna, puer, nimiumque potentia regna;

cur opus adfectas, ambitiose, novum?

an, quod ubique, tuum est? tua sunt Heliconia tempe?

vix etiam Phoebus iam lyra tuta sua est?

cum bene surrexit versu nova pagina primo,

attenuat nervos proximus ille meos;

nec mihi materia est numeris levioribus apta,

aut puer aut longas compta puella comas.'

questus eram, pharetra cum protinus ille soluta

legit in exitium spicula facta meum,

lunavitque genu sinuosum fortiter arcum,

'quod' que 'canas, vates, accipe' dixit 'opus!'

me miserum! certas habuit puer ille sagittas.

uror, et in vacuo pectore regnat Amor.

sex mihi surgat opus numeris, in quinque residat:

ferrea cum vestris bella valete modis!

cingere litorea flaventia tempora myrto,

Musa, per undenos emodulanda pedes!

How does Ovid's personification of Elegy inspire his poetry, and what makes the second halves of pentameters so euphonic?

stat vetus et multos incaedua silva per annos;

credibile est illi numen inesse loco.

fons sacer in medio speluncaque pumice pendens,

et latere ex omni dulce queruntur aves.

hic ego dum spatior tectus nemoralibus umbris —

quod mea, quaerebam, Musa moveret opus —

venit odoratos Elegia nexa capillos,

et, puto, pes illi longior alter erat.

forma decens, vestis tenuissima, vultus amantis,

et pedibus vitium causa decoris erat.

How is Elegy's self-characterisation a reflection of her metre, themes and relationship to Cupid?

sum levis, et mecum levis est, mea cura, Cupido;

non sum materia fortior ipsa mea.

How is the clash between Hercules and Antaeus on lines 3-4 illustrated by puns and metre?

digredimur paulum, rursusque ad bella coimus,

inque gradu stetimus, certi non cedere, eratque

cum pede pes iunctus, totoque ego pectore pronus

et digitos digitis et frontem fronte premebam.

Exercise 6: Metrical patterns

Only the first feet of dactylic pentameter and hexameter are metrically customisable since the final syllables are always fixed. This means that there are only four possible patterns of spondees and dactyls in pentameter (DD, DS, SD, SS), and sixteen in hexameter, (ranging from SSSS to DDDD).

Poets will often compose with a pattern that fittingly represents their subject matter. Scan and translate each extract, then record the pattern of each line and jot down some ideas in answer to the prompts which we shall discuss further in class.

How might the metrical patterns represent the motion of Icarus' *infirmæ pennae*, and the motion of the *aequoreae aquae*?

dum petit infirmis nimium sublimia pennis

Icarus, aequoreas nomine fecit aquas.

How might the metrical pattern represent the motion of horses?

... it clamor, et agmine facto

quadrupedante putrem sonitu quatit ungula campum.

How might the metrical patterns represent the sounds and motions of the Cyclopes blacksmithing?

illi inter sese multa vi brachia tollunt

in numerum versantque tenaci forcipe massam

How might the metrical pattern of line 2 represent the *mora* Bacchus created? How might line 3 complement *rapite* and represent Pentheus' desire to combat *mora*. How might line 4 represent an ironic punishment for Bacchus.

'Praebuimus longis' Pentheus 'ambagibus aures,'

inquit 'ut ira mora vires absumere posset.

praecipitem, famuli, rapite hunc cruciataque diris

corpora tormentis Stygiae demittite nocti!

How might the metrical pattern and puns represent the motion of Phaethon's horses in comparison to Tethys?

interea volucres Pyrois et Eous et Aethon,

Solis equi, quartusque Phlegon hinnitibus auras

flammiferis implent pedibusque repagula pulsan.

quae postquam Tethys, fatorum ignara nepotis,

reppulit, et facta est immensi copia caeli,

corripuere viam pedibusque per aera motis.

How might the metrical pattern represent the Underworld, and the motion of Aeneas and the Sibyl?

ibant obscuri sola sub nocte per umbram,

perque domos Ditis vacuas et inania regna:

How might the metrical pattern and alliteration of line 3 represent Aeneas' anxious *animus* and the metaphor of line 2?

... Laomedontius heros

cuncta uidens magno curarum fluctuat aestu,

atque animum nunc huc celerem nunc diuidit illuc

in partisque rapit uarias perque omnia uersat.

How might the metrical pattern and tricolon of line 4 represent the futility of Io trying to escape Jupiter?

ne fuge me!" fugiebat enim. iam pascua Lernae

consitaque arboribus Lyrcea reliquerat arva,

cum deus inducta latas caligine terras

occultuit tenuitque fugam rapuitque pudorem.

Exercise 7: Elision

Virgil made elision one of the most important features of his hexameter, using it skillfully to interlock phrases and represent the complexity of his narrative – wrath, fear, struggle, and sadness. Juno's wrathful soliloquy is the first direct speech in the *Aeneid*, and exemplifies this with fourteen elisions.

What might the elisions, metrical pattern and asyndeton represent the cyclops Polyphemus?

uix ea fatus erat summo cum monte uidemus

ipsum inter pecudes uasta se mole mouentem

pastorem Polyphemum et litora nota petentem,

monstrum horrendum, informe, ingens, cui lumen ademptum.

How might the elision represent Virgil's description of nightfall?

nox ruit et fuscis tellurem amplexitur alis.

What might the elision and metrical pattern of line three represent the brutality of Perseus, the great-grandson of Abas?

Torquet in hunc hastam calido de vulnere raptam
ultor Abantiades; media quae nare recepta
cervice exacta est in partesque eminet ambas.

How might the metrical pattern of line 2 represent the Greeks' fatigue from war?

*saepe fugam Danai Troia cupiere relictam
moliri, et longo fessi discedere bello;*

What might the elision on line 3 reflect about Dido's groan?

*ter sese attollens cubitoque adnixa levavit;
ter revoluta toro est, oculisque errantibus alto
quaesivit caelo lucem ingemuitque reperta.*

What might these elisions represent about Juno's speech?

cum luno, aeternum servans sub pectore vulnus,

haec secum: "Mene incepto desistere victam,

nec posse Italia Teucrorum avertere regem!

quippe vetor fatis. Pallasne exurere classem

Argivum atque ipsos potuit submergere ponto,

unius ob noxam et furias Aiakis Oilei?

ipsa, louis rapidum iaculata e nubibus ignem,

disiecitque rates euertitque aequora uentis,

illum exspirantem transfixo pectore flammis

turbine corripuit scopuloque infixit acuto.

ast ego, quae divum incedo regina, louisque

et soror et coniunx, una cum gente tot annos

bella gero! Et quisquam numen lunonis adorat

praeterea aut supplex aris imponet honorem?"

N.B. the first word of the *Iliad* is 'menin', the Greek term for wrath.

How might the elision and word order represent Rome's history with Carthage?

urbs antiqua fuit (Tyrri tenuere coloni)

Karthago, Italiam contra Tiberinaque longe.

How might the elision and word order represent the siege of Troy?

Dardaniae cingique urbem obsidione uideret.

How might the elision and metrical pattern represent Palinurus' struggle?

paulatim adnabam terrae; iam tuta tenebam.

How might the elisions represent Aeneas' speech?

implevi clamore vias, maestusque Creusam

nequiquam ingeminans iterumque iterumque vocavi

How might the elision and repetition of *Italiam* represent about Achates' speech?

Cum procul obscuros collis humilemque videmus

Italiam. Italiam primus conclamat Achates,

Italiam laeto socii clamore salutant.

How might the elision and word order represent Arruns' disappearance into the ranks?

haud secus ex oculis se turbidus abstulit Arruns

contentusque fuga mediis se immiscuit armis.

How might the elision and word order represent Mercury's disappearance into the night?

"Heia age, rumpe moras. Varium et mutabile semper

femina" sic fatus nocti se immiscuit atrae.

How might the elisions, lack of caesuras, and metrical patterns represent Aeneas' struggle?

tertia sed postquam maiore hastilia nisu

adgredior genibusque adversae obluctor harenae.

How might the elisions reflect the Cyclopes' welding metal?

ingentem clipeum informant, unum omnia contra

tela Latinorum, septenosque orbibus orbis

impediunt...

Exercise 8: Caesura and Diaeresis

How might the caesuras and metrical pattern represent the sailors' rapid response to the changing conditions at sea?

*vela cadunt, remis insurgimus; haud mora, nautae
adnixa torquent spumas et caerula verrunt.*

How might the caesuras, diaeresis and metrical pattern of the *incipit* to Cicero's poem about saving Rome explain why he was ridiculed for it.

O fortunatam natam me consule Romam!

How might the absence of a caesura on line 4 represent a maze?

*ut quondam Creta fertur Labyrinthus in alta
parietibus textum caecis iter ancipitemque
mille uiis habuisse dolum, qua signa sequendi
frangeret indepressus et inremeabilis error.*

How might the diaeresis represent the bull shaking off the axe?

*qualis mugitus, fugit cum saucius aram
taurus et incertam excussit cervice securim.*

Exercise 9: Performance

The ultimate goal of reading Latin verse as it was meant to be read requires practice performing it aloud. In the passage below (spreading across both pages) Anchises voices Virgil's vision of Roman greatness. Scan each line (you do not need to translate them) and practice reading them aloud with a [metronome](#), starting at 50BPM and working your way up to 80BPM – as modelled by [Johan Winge](#) on YouTube.

Nec vero Alcides tantum telluris obivit,
fixerit aeripedem cervam licet, aut Erymanthi
pacarit nemora, et Lernam tremefecerit arcu;
nec, qui pampineis victor iuga flectit habenis,
Liber, agens celso Nysae de vertice tigres.
aut dubitamus adhuc virtute extendere vires,
aut metus Ausonia prohibet consistere terra?
“Quis procul ille autem ramis insignis olivae
sacra ferens? Nosco crines incanaque menta
regis Romani, primus qui legibus urbem
fundabit, Curibus parvis et paupere terra
missus in imperium magnum. Cui deinde subibit,
otia qui rumpet patriae residesque movebit

Tullus in arma viros et iam desueta triumphis
agmina. Quem iuxta sequitur iactantior Ancus,
nunc quoque iam nimium gaudens popularibus auris.
Vis et Tarquinius reges, animamque superbam
ultoris Bruti, fascesque videre receptos?
Consulis imperium hic primus saevasque secures
accipiet, natosque pater nova bella moventes
ad poenam pulchra pro libertate vocabit.
Infelix, utcumque ferent ea facta minores,
vincet amor patriae laudumque immensa cupido.
Quin Decios Drusosque procul saevumque securi
aspice Torquatum et referentem signa Camillum.
Illae autem, paribus quas fulgere cernis in armis,

concordes animae nunc et dum nocte premuntur,
heu quantum inter se bellum, si lumina vitae
attigerint, quantas acies stragemque ciebunt!
Aggeribus socer Alpinis atque arce Monoeci
descendens, gener adversis instructus Eois.
Ne, pueri, ne tanta animis adsuescite bella,
neu patriae validas in viscera vertite vires;
tuque prior, tu parce, genus qui ducis Olympo,
proice tela manu, sanguis meus!—
“Ille triumphata Capitolia ad alta Corintho
victor aget currum, caesis insignis Achivis.
Eruet ille Argos Agamemnoniasque Mycenae,
ipsumque Aeaciden, genus armipotentis Achilli,
ultus avos Troiae, templa et temerata Minervae.
Quis te, magne Cato, tacitum, aut te, Cosse, relinquat?

Quis Gracchi genus, aut geminos, duo fulmina belli,
Scipiadas, cladem Libyae, parvoque potentem
Fabricium vel te sulco Serrane, serentem?
quo fessum rapitis, Fabii? Tu Maxumus ille es,
unus qui nobis cunctando restituis rem.
Excudent alii spirantia mollius aera,
credo equidem, vivos ducent de marmore vultus,
orabunt causas melius, caelique meatus
describent radio, et surgentia sidera dicent:
tu regere imperio populos, Romane, memento;
hae tibi erunt artes; pacisque imponere morem,
parcere subiectis, et debellare superbos.”

If you enjoyed this exercise and have found it useful elsewhere to think of Latin verse like music, read Theodora Kopestonsky's essay [Never Out of Style: Teaching Latin Love Poetry with Pop Music](#) which discusses the dactylic nature of the Notorious B.I.G.'s *Big Poppa* and Maroon 5's *What Lovers Do*, and compares Taylor Swift's *Blank Space* to poems by Catullus.

Exercise 10: hexameter.co

After completing all the exercises in this booklet, register to the website 'hexameter.co' and accept the invitation in your Outlook inboxes to join the virtual classroom.

This website was designed by a Latin teacher, called Ben Johnson, who was inspired by the rating system used by 'chess.com' and wanted his students to receive immediate feedback and scan lines of poetry that were suited to their ability.

From the home screen, click 'Start Scanning' and select Ovid as your author; this website has a bank of 10,239 lines of dactylic hexameter from Ovid alone. Your screen should look like this:

1000

My Rating

Long	Short	Foot	Elision	Caesura	Diaeresis
—	˘	/	◡	//	

inrorant foliis, ac, dum licet, oraque praestant

RD: 350

Correct: 0

Incorrect: 0

Streak: 0

Ovid's Metamorphoses 9.369

Rating: 1003

Upon registration, your rating will be 1000. Your goal is to identify whether the first four feet are spondees or dactyls, and submit the answer in the abbreviated format, e.g. SDSD. You can drag and drop the symbols above to annotate the line as you see fit. Depending on if you are correct or not, your rating will increase or decrease and your next line of hexameter will be harder or easier.

The average line rating of Ovid is 1075, so for the exam it is best that your rating be as high above this as possible.

The major problem with this website is that when you are incorrect it does not explain why. It shows the number of elisions and the correct combination of dactyls and spondees but does not map them onto the line. Record the lines below which you cannot resolve, to then discuss them in class and revise from:

This image shows a blank sheet of white paper with horizontal ruling lines. The lines are evenly spaced and extend across the width of the page. There are no margins, text, or other markings on the paper.

Exceptions of Latin prosody

As is true for most things Latin, there are exceptions to the rules. On this page and the next are some of the most notable exceptions which are worth being aware of (but not necessarily understanding fully). Please note that this page has been deliberately placed at the end of this booklet because, based on the past exam papers, it is highly unlikely that you are expected to scan something of this difficulty. Nonetheless, knowledge is power. If you wish to read a comprehensive overview of these exceptions and more, read Charles Anthon's *A System of Latin Prosody and Metre*.

Elegiac couplets are usually self-contained sentences but can sometimes extend into the next couplet(s). This often occurs if a noun is introduced since the original couplet is spent qualifying it and the actual sentence is expressed in the next couplet(s). For Ovid, this will often simply involve two couplets, i.e. his description of Ariadne waking up on the beach (*Ars* 1.529-32). But there are greater instances, i.e. his four couplet description of his hometown, or his six couplet catalogue of eight ways to trick the guardian of a woman you fancy.

5The fifth foot of dactylic hexameter can sometimes be a spondee, leading to the entire line being called a spondaic line. Catullus' epyllion, in imitation of Alexandrian poetry, contains 30 spondaic lines but Virgil has only 33 spondaic lines across all his poetry, and Ovid has even less.

The first syllable of the verb *fio* is typically long in all its tenses, however, it becomes short when followed by 'er'.

The verb *aio* was originally *aiio* (pronounced *ai-yo*) and so the first syllable is sometimes treated as a diphthong and long by nature, meaning that *ait* is monosyllabic, othertimes *ait* can be two shorts.

Names are difficult to quantify. Greek names are especially difficult when transliterated into Latin because the long vowels (eta and omega) are represented by the letters E and O which also represent the short vowels (episolon and omicron). Greek names which begin with *Pro-* have that first syllable short (unlike Latin words with the prefix *pro-*). The ending *-eus* of Greek names (with the genitive *-eos*) is pronounced as a diphthong, unless the poet has chosen to Latinise their name into a second declension noun in which case the E and U are pronounced separately. For example, *Promētheus* → *Pro-mē-theus* (U — —).

The caesura sometimes blocks an elision from occurring, and can make the preceding syllable (that is otherwise short) become long. Sometimes, when elision ought to occur, it does not – this is called hiatus. Hiatus is allowed after interjections and sometimes after long final vowels and diphthongs. Sometimes, these long final vowels become short and do not elide – this is called semi-hiatus. Elision can even occur across lines of poetry – this is called hypermetre. Hypermetre typically occurs when large lists are being stated, or in the direct speech of someone while angry.

The letter E of the fifth declension genitive and dative singular ending *-eī* in quantity, e.g. it is long in *diēī*, short in *speī*, and varies in *fideī* and *reī*.

Past papers

These are the five pairs of lines selected in the 2019-2023 papers. While scanning them, you should realise that they are much easier than the exercises presented to you throughout this booklet.

tolle, precor. Non nos odium regnique cupido

compulit ad bellum; pro coniuge movimus arma.

ora super postes adfixaque brachia pendent,

squalidaque humanis ossibus albet humus

Nec dubito quin sint et in hoc non pauca libello

barbara: non hominis culpa, sed ista loci.

“quae mea culpa tuam,” dixit “carissime, mentem

vertit? Ubi est quae cura mei prior esse solebat?

ut videt extinctum, telo quod inhaeserat illi

incubuit moriensque suum complexa maritum est.

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